

WHAT IS FLU AND HOW TO STAY SAFE

- There are four types of influenza viruses: A, B, C and D
- Influenza A is the most common in India. It has two sub-types: H1N1 and H3N2
- H1N1 caused the swine flu pandemic in 2009
- H3N2 symptoms last longer, recur quicker. India has seen more H3N2 cases than during the pre-pandemic period. This is due to reduced immunity to the virus, climate change, pollution
- In the 2023 winter flu season, 50% of those hospitalised with severe respiratory syndrome had H3N2. There was a country-wide spurt in H1N1 cases too
- New flu vaccines protect against two strains each of Type A and B and are highly recommended prior to flu season (June-September, November-March)

Illustration by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

are staying on for almost two weeks."

While the flu is not generally associated with serious illness—it causes upper respiratory infection, with classic symptoms that last for five-seven days—some patients do go on to develop serious symptoms. "People who are more vulnerable are the same as during Covid—elderly, children, pregnant women, people with medical comorbidities like uncontrolled diabetes, heart disease, liver disease, cancer, people on immunosuppressive drugs," says Dr Budhiraja. Being at higher risk, they can develop pneumonia and other complications. "There is a rise in hospitalisations in the past few weeks with complications of flu, especially those who have COPD (Chronic Obstructive Pulmonary Disease), asthma or chronic bronchitis," adds Dr Budhiraja.

What is causing the flu?

It is not changes in the virus. "The virus isn't becoming more aggressive," says Dr Dipu T.S., associate professor at the Division of Infectious Diseases in Amrita Hospital, Kochi. "In fact, our exposure, particularly to H3N2, has been less." The intensity of the winter and rising pollution levels in the north this year are worsening symptoms and spreading infections. Delhi, for example, saw its coldest January in at least 12 years. Other parts of the north also battled a cold wave, conditions that allow the flu virus to live for longer outdoors. Some data also suggest that extreme cold slows down human immune systems.